

North and Central America



The continent of North America stretches from the Arctic Ocean in the north to the isthmus connecting Central America in the south with South America, and includes the many islands of the Caribbean. The US, Canada, and many of the islands are predominantly English-speaking. Mexico is the world's most populous Spanish-speaking nation. Once entirely colonized by European countries, all but a few islands are now independent.

United States



The US is the world's fourth-largest country, and politically dominates most of the Americas.

c.35000BCE Possible first date for human explorers to cross the land bridge from Siberia and begin to hunt and roam in the far northwest of the continent.

c.13000BCE Earliest evidence of colonization in the northwest of the continent as the last Ice Age ends.

c.9000BCE Hunter-gatherers spread to the Great Plains and the southern deserts.

c.3000BCE First farmers grow crops in the southwest.

c.100BCE The Hopewell people settle in the Ohio Valley and begin to build burial mounds.

c.400 Hohokam people begin building villages in the southwest. Soon after this, hunters on the Great Plains first use bows and arrows to kill buffalo.

c.600 People in the Mississippi River valley begin to build small towns and burial mounds.

c.700 The city of Cahokia is built in the northern Mississippi River valley. A vast, earthen temple mound, used for religious purposes, dominates the city.

800 Corn becomes an important source of food in the eastern woodlands; within 200 years, permanent villages are built throughout the region. Hardier strains of corn and beans increase food production in the Mississippi valley, allowing the population to increase.

900 The first farming villages are constructed on the Great Plains.

900 The Anasazi people of Chaco Canyon in New Mexico build a network of villages linked by roads. At Pueblo Bonito they construct a D-shaped, four-story apartment building capable of housing up to 1,200 people in 800 rooms.

c.1000 Vikings build a settlement in what is now Newfoundland, the first contact between Europe and the Americas.

1200 Cahokia is at the height of its power, with more than 10,000 people.

1492 Christopher Columbus makes the first of his four voyages to the Americas.

1498 On his second voyage, Italian John Cabot explores the coast of North America as far south as Delaware.

1499 Italian navigator Amerigo Vespucci voyages to South America and the Caribbean. He is the first European navigator to realize that the lands Columbus had reached were not in Asia but part of a new continent. He called this land mass *Mundus Novus* ("new world"). When the German cartographer Martin Waldseemüller wrote a geography book in 1507, he named this world "the land of Amerigo, or America, after Amerigo, its discoverer..." At first, this name applied to South America only, but in 1538 Flemish mapmaker Gerardus Mercator became the first person to designate both North and South America on a world map.

1524–25 Italian navigator Giovanni da Verrazano, exploring under French auspices, sails down the Atlantic coast as far as Cape Fear, North Carolina. On the way he passes into what is now New York Harbor, through narrows that today bear his name.

1526 The Spanish establish a settlement at San Miguel de Gualdape in what is now Georgetown, South Carolina. Among their number are a few African slaves. The colony only lasts a year, as half of the Spanish die. The Africans revolt, set fire to the settlement, and live among the American Indians as the first black settlers in North America. As the Spanish continue their exploration of the region, more African slaves escape.

1527–28 Pánfilo de Narváez, a Spanish conquistador, explores the west coast of Florida and the Gulf of Mexico. His expedition ends in disaster and only four men survive by making an eight-year trek on foot to another Spanish settlement.

1539–42 Hernando de Soto follows on from the Narváez expedition and roams around unsuccessfully in search of gold, crossing the Mississippi during his travels.

1565 A Spanish expedition led by Pedro Menéndez sets up the colony of St. Augustine on the west coast of Florida, the oldest permanent US city founded by Europeans. Among their number are African slaves. The nearby French colony at Fort Caroline, established in 1564, is destroyed by the Spanish as a potential threat to their transatlantic fleets carrying gold bullion to Spain.

1584 An English colony is established by explorer Sir Walter Raleigh on Roanoke Island and is resettled in 1587. It vanishes without trace by 1590.

1607 The first successful English colony, Jamestown, named after English king James I, is established in Virginia. The Dutch sail up the Hudson River to establish Fort Nassau in what is now Albany in 1614. They later settle in New York and in 1626 purchase Manhattan Island from the American Indians. In 1638 the Swedes establish their own colony of New Sweden on the Delaware River, although it is seized by the Dutch in 1655.

1619 Twenty Africans, among them three women, arrive in Jamestown, Virginia, aboard a Dutch ship and are sold as indentured servants, the forerunners of slaves. When William Tucker is born around 1623, he becomes the first African-American born in the 13 colonies.

1620 The Pilgrims arrive at Cape Cod, Massachusetts.

1620s The transatlantic slave trade gathers pace as France joins England and the Netherlands in the trade. African slaves are brought to New York (1626), Maryland and Massachusetts (1634), New Hampshire (1645), and other English colonies. By 1649 there are 300 African slaves in Virginia, and at least 2,000 by 1671. By 1675 the total number of African slaves in the North American colonies grows to more than 5,000.

1665 Following the second Anglo-Dutch War, control of the New Netherlands passes to the English crown. The colony and the city of New Amsterdam are both renamed New York. The English are now the dominant colonial power on the eastern seaboard, establishing 13 colonies from New Hampshire and Massachusetts in the north to Georgia in the south. The French control the Mississippi River valley, the Great Lakes, and the St. Lawrence River valley of Canada, while the Spanish control Florida, the southwest, and the west coast of North America.

1671 Thomas Batts and Robert Fallam, two English explorers, are the first Europeans to find a way through the Appalachian Mountains. They follow the Staunton River through the Blue Ridge and emerge on the westerly flowing New River, following it to the Ohio River. Soon, other explorers are discovering new routes through the mountain range.

1680–82 Robert de la Salle, a French trader, explores south from French Canada and sails the length of the Mississippi River to the Gulf of Mexico, claiming the entire region for France.

1681 Pennsylvania is established as a Quaker colony by William Penn.

1689–97 King William's War, the American extension of the War of the League of Augsburg between France and, among others, England, sees the French and their Huron allies raid New England. Further conflict between the two colonial powers breaks out during Queen Anne's War, known in Europe as the War of the Spanish Succession (1702–13), during which the French raid Connecticut.



The Pilgrims

A 19th-century image depicts the relieved English pilgrims landing at Plymouth Rock, Massachusetts, in December 1620—a seminal moment in American history. The pilgrims were a group of puritans intent on preserving their cultural identity. Luckily, they found an abandoned settlement.